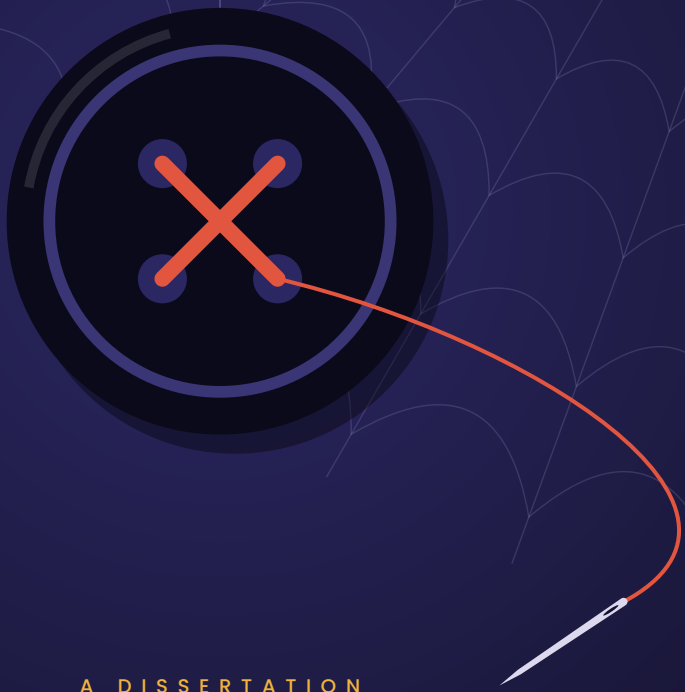


A DISSERTATION

THE RIGHT TO LACK

Maternal Totality, Arachnopoetics, and the Unsewn Eye in Neil Gaiman's and Henry Selick's Coraline

TOWARD A LACUNARY HUMANISM

OCTOBER 2026

THE RIGHT TO LACK

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SUMMARY OF THE ARGUMENT

Abstract

THIS DISSERTATION ADVANCES A new theoretical framework, *lacunary humanism*, through a sustained reading of Neil Gaiman's novella *Coraline* (2002) and Henry Selick's stop-motion adaptation (2009). Against readings that construe the Other Mother as a figure of monstrous maternal *power*—whether in the psychoanalytic idiom of the archaic mother or in the ideological-critical idiom of postfeminist containment—it argues that the beldam is more precisely a figure of *Maternal Totality*: a mode of power that secures attachment by abolishing lack. Her offence is not deprivation but completion; her instrument is not cruelty but perfect provision; and her signature act, the sewing of buttons into a child's eyes, is the literal suture of the gap through which a subject desires, judges, and becomes.

Reconstructing the genealogies that converge in the text—from Plato's Diotima, Pico della Mirandola, Montaigne and Kant through Freud, Klein, Winnicott and Lacan; from Wollstonecraft, Mill and Beauvoir through Rich, Irigaray, Kristeva, Chodorow and Jessica Benjamin—the study demonstrates that *Coraline* stages a convergence between two traditions ordinarily held apart: the feminist critique of motherhood as institution, which has shown that the ideal of the all-supplying mother devours mothers and daughters alike, and the humanist defence of the unfinished subject, which from the Renaissance to Arendt has located human dignity in indeterminacy and new beginning. These, it is argued, are a single discovery articulated in two idioms; *Coraline*, by casting the enemy of the unfinished self as a perfect mother, is the text in which their identity becomes legible.

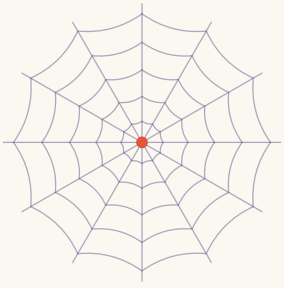
Five propositions are derived and defended: the Axiom of Lack, the Principle of Maternal Totality, the Right to Insufficiency, the Ethics of the Unsewn Eye, and Relinquishing Poiesis. A metamedial chapter shows that both texts indict their own fantasy-making: novella and film are themselves Other worlds built by adults to captivate children, and their figure of a needle-fingered maker who animates dolls in order to possess a child constitutes an auto-critique of children's literature and of animation as such. A chapter on *arachnopoetics* distinguishes two ethics of making figured by the spider: the web that captures and the filament that bridges. The dissertation concludes by extending the *beldam paradigm* to contemporary systems of frictionless satisfaction, proposing that *Coraline* furnishes a children's-literature foundation for a civic ethics of the protected lack.

PRELIMINARIES

Note on Texts, Citation, and Method

REFERENCES TO THE NOVELLA are to Neil Gaiman, *Coraline*, illustrated by Dave McKean (London: Bloomsbury; New York: HarperCollins, 2002), cited by chapter. References to the film are to *Coraline*, written and directed by Henry Selick (LAIKA / Focus Features, 2009), cited by sequence. The primary texts are engaged through close paraphrase and chapter reference rather than extended quotation. Translations from public-domain Latin, French, and German sources (Pico, Montaigne, Perrault, Schelling, Kant, Freud) are the author's own.

Where novella and film diverge, the divergence is treated not as a problem of fidelity but as interpretive evidence: the adaptation is read as a second, sometimes dissenting, reading of its source. Methodologically, the study proceeds by what Walter Benjamin, in the epistemo-critical prologue to the *Trauerspiel* book (1928), and Theodor Adorno, in *Negative Dialectics* (1966), called *constellation*: concepts drawn from discrete traditions are set in configuration around an object until the object illuminates them in turn. Genealogical attention is paid throughout to the originators of the ideas the texts inherit, so that the argument can distinguish what *Coraline* receives from what it transforms.



What fairy tales give the child is his first clear idea of the possible defeat of bogey.

G. K. CHESTERTON

"THE RED ANGEL," TREMENDOUS TRIFLES (1909)

INTRODUCTION

The Scandal of Sufficiency



I *The Problem*

A GIRL IS OFFERED everything a child could be imagined to want: a mother who cooks for her with ceremonial abundance, a father who sings for her, neighbours who perform for her alone, a bedroom whose toys fly and whose wardrobe holds marvels, a garden that blooms in the shape of her face, and—most insidiously—a world that pronounces her name correctly. The price is two black buttons, sewn into her eyes. Criticism has generally located the horror of *Coraline* in the price. This dissertation locates it in the offer. The beldam's world is terrifying not because it withholds but because it supplies; not because the Other Mother is cruel but because she is, in the only sense she understands, perfect. The scandal at the centre of the text is the scandal of sufficiency.

To take that scandal seriously is to reorganise the interpretive field. If the Other Mother is a figure of deprivation, *Coraline* is a familiar fable of the bad mother and the good, its moral a comforting reaffirmation of the hearth. If she is a figure of *completion*, the fable becomes a philosophical argument—one that bears with unusual precision on psychoanalytic theories of desire, on feminist theories of motherhood, on humanist theories of the person, and on the ethics of making worlds for others to inhabit.

II *Corpus and Context*

Gaiman began the novella in the early 1990s for his elder daughter and completed it roughly a decade later for his younger. Its heroine's name, by his own account, originated as a typographical slip for 'Caroline'—a contingency the text converts into a theme, since the adults of the primary world persistently misname her. Published in 2002 with Dave McKean's scratched, spidery illustrations, the novella received the Hugo and Nebula Awards for Best Novella and the Bram Stoker Award for Best Work for Young Readers: an unusual convergence of science-fiction, fantasy, and horror institutions around a book for children.

Selick's adaptation—LAIKA's first feature, nominated for the Academy Award for Best Animated Feature—relocated the action from an English house divided into flats to the Pink Palace Apartments in Ashland, Oregon. It added Wybie Lovat, the landlady's grandson, and a doll in Coraline's likeness that serves as the beldam's eye; supplied an opening credit sequence in which needle-tipped hands unpick and re-stitch a doll; and consummated the beldam's latent arachnid imagery by transforming her world, at its climax, into a web. These alterations are read here as commentary. The film is the first and most consequential critic of the novella.

A note on the author is required, because this study's argument concerns adult makers and the power they hold over those who depend on them. Since 2024, Gaiman has been accused of sexual abuse by multiple women. Tortoise Media's podcast *Master: The Allegations Against Neil Gaiman* (2024) aired the first accounts, and in January 2025 *New York* magazine published allegations of assault, abuse, and coercion from eight women. The most detailed accusation is Scarlett Pavlovich's. She alleges that Gaiman sexually assaulted her repeatedly in New Zealand in 2022, beginning on the night they met, while she worked as nanny to the son of Gaiman and Amanda Palmer; that she was 22 and homeless when she met Palmer, who brought her into the household; that she stayed because she depended on the job, the housing, and Gaiman's promised help with her writing; and that Palmer knew of the risk and presented her to him. In February 2025 she sued in U.S. federal courts under the Trafficking Victims Protection Act and state law.

Gaiman denies ever engaging in non-consensual sex. His lawyers characterised the relationship as brief and consensual and told the court that New Zealand police had investigated and found no merit. The U.S. suits were withdrawn or dismissed, the latter on the ground that New Zealand is the proper forum, and in June 2026 the Seventh Circuit affirmed the Wisconsin dismissal without reaching the merits (*Pavlovich v. Gaiman*, 179 F.4th 603). No court has ruled on whether the allegations are true. Sources: Associated Press, 9 February 2026; ICv2, 1 July 2026.

This dissertation's claims concern the works, not their author, and none depends on resolving the allegations. They bear on the argument nonetheless, with uncomfortable precision. The thesis reads *Coraline* as an analysis of power that presents itself as care and possession that calls itself love, and it credits the texts with indicting the adult maker's wish to keep what he has made. The accusations, which Gaiman denies, allege that pattern—employment, shelter, and patronage used as leverage over a young woman who depended on them—in the conduct of the novella's author. A reading that credited the novella's ethic of release to its author's character would therefore be unsupportable, and none is offered here. Where later chapters speak of the works' self-correction, the claim is about what the works do.

III *The State of the Question*

Scholarship has organised itself around two paradigms. The first, developmental and psychoanalytic, reads the text as a narrative of separation and individuation. David Rudd's Lacanian account of identity (2008) and Richard Gooding's study of uncanniness and narrative form (2008) locate its power in the drama of a self constituted across a boundary, while Karen Coats (2008) situates Gaiman's Gothic

within the psychic work that horror performs for young readers. The second paradigm, ideological-critical, finds in the text a conservative containment: Elizabeth Parsons, Naarah Sawers, and Kate McInally (2008) read *Coraline* as a postfeminist fairy tale in which a girl's empowerment is purchased by the demonisation of maternal power and rendered in the idiom of neoliberal self-reliance.

The two paradigms disagree about value but share a premise: that the Other Mother signifies maternal *power*, whether as the archaic omnipotence the subject must escape or as the female authority the text must discipline. This dissertation contests the premise. The beldam signifies not the power of mothers but an *ideal* of motherhood: the mother without lack, who adapts perfectly, gives totally, and never fails. She is, in Adrienne Rich's terms, the institution rather than the experience of motherhood, pushed to the point at which the institution consumes its subjects. Read as Maternal Totality rather than maternal power, the developmental and ideological readings are not refuted but recomposed: the psychoanalytic drama becomes the critique of an ideal, and the apparent misogyny becomes a defence of real mothers against the ideal that would replace them.

IV *Thesis*

This dissertation argues that *Coraline* is the founding fable of what I term *lacunary humanism*: a humanism that locates the dignity of the person not in self-sufficiency, plenitude, or mastery, but in a constitutive and protectable lack—the gap through which desire, recognition, freedom, and futurity enter a life. The beldam is the antagonist of this humanism not because she is a mother, nor even because she is monstrous, but because she is total.

Coraline's refusal is condensed in the novella's simplest sentence of resistance: her insistence that no one truly wishes to be handed whatever they wish for, since a desire fulfilled without remainder would mean nothing. That refusal brings two traditions into coincidence. The feminist critique of motherhood as institution has shown that the ideal of the perfect mother devours mothers and daughters alike. The humanist defence of the unfinished subject, from Pico's faceless Adam to Arendt's natality, has located human dignity in indeterminacy and new beginning. These are one discovery in two idioms, and *Coraline*, by casting the enemy of the unfinished self as a perfect mother, makes their identity legible.

A third claim completes the argument. Both novella and film recognise themselves in the beldam. Each is an Other world built by adults to captivate a child, and each figures its own maker—Gaiman's narrating voice, Selick's needle-handed animators—in the image of the creature who builds a world in order

to keep a child inside it. That self-recognition is converted into an ethic: *relinquishing poiesis*, a mode of making that holds in order to let go.

v *Plan of the Work*

Chapter 1 reconstructs the folkloric and literary genealogy of the threshold, showing that *Coraline* inherits the oldest grammar of children's fiction while reassigning its positions of villain and rescuer. Chapter 2 reads the Other house through Freud's uncanny, Bachelard's topoanalysis, and the metaphysics of the copy, and identifies the cat as the one being without a double. Chapter 3 assembles the psychoanalytic genealogy of Maternal Totality from Freud, Klein, Winnicott, Lacan, Kristeva, and the feminist relational theorists. Chapter 4 situates the text among feminist works from Wollstonecraft to Morrison and answers the postfeminist charge. Chapter 5 reads the beldam's offer as the negation, term by term, of the humanist tradition from Pico to Arendt. Chapter 6 turns to the texts' reflexive critique of their own media; Chapter 7 develops arachnopoetics; Chapter 8 formalises lacunary humanism in five propositions. The conclusion extends the beldam paradigm to the attention economy.

CHAPTER ONE

Genealogies of the Threshold

Fairy Tale, Folklore, and the Grammar of the Door

> Coraline *is written in the oldest grammar of children's fiction—door, key, feast, wager, rescue—but it reassigns two of that grammar's positions. The villain's place passes from stepmother and male predator to an explicitly maternal double; the rescuer's place passes from prince or mother to the daughter.*

1.1 *The Epigraph and the Identity of the Dragon*

THE NOVELLA OPENS UNDER a sentence attributed to G. K. Chesterton, in Gaiman's compressed paraphrase: fairy tales are more than true, not because they tell us dragons exist, but because they tell us dragons can be beaten. The source is "The Red Angel" (*Tremendous Trifles*, 1909), where Chesterton's formulation is pedagogical rather than aphoristic. The child already knows fear, since fear is in the world; "What fairy tales give the child is his first clear idea of the possible defeat of bogey." Gaiman's compression shifts the emphasis from the child's acquisition of an idea to the dragon's defeasibility, and so announces a structure: the text will introduce a dragon and teach its defeat.

The identity of that dragon is less obvious than it appears. In Erich Neumann's Jungian mythography (*The Origins and History of Consciousness*, 1949), the hero's dragon-fight is the ego's struggle to emerge from the uroboric embrace of the Great Mother in her Terrible aspect: the dragon *is* the devouring maternal. Read through Neumann, the epigraph names the beldam before she appears, and the novella closes the circuit when it likens her attachment to Coraline to a miser's attachment to coin and a dragon's to its hoard. The dragon of the epigraph is a mother who loves as dragons love gold.

Chesterton supplies a second key in "The Ethics of Elfland" (*Orthodoxy*, 1908), where he formulates the Doctrine of Conditional Joy: "In the fairy tale an incomprehensible happiness rests upon an incomprehensible condition." In his examples—a box not to be opened, a lamp not to be lit, an apple not to be eaten—the condition is always a veto, and joy is preserved by abstention. The beldam inverts the doctrine. Her condition is not a prohibition but an *incorporation*: happiness is offered on condition that the child permit a positive act upon her body. Where Chesterton's fairyland teaches gratitude by asking the hero to refrain, the beldam's demands the surrender of the faculty—sight—through which wonder is possible. The ethics of elfland are thus both the text's inheritance and its target.

1.2 *Door, Key, Garden*

The small door in the drawing-room wall inherits a dense lineage. Carroll's Alice finds a golden key on a glass table and a door too small to pass, through which she glimpses "the loveliest garden you ever saw" (*Alice's Adventures in Wonderland*, 1865); *Through the Looking-Glass* (1871) supplies the reversed house. Perrault's "La Barbe bleue" (1697) supplies the forbidden door and the key that betrays: *la clef était Fée*, the key was enchanted, and its bloodstain would not wash away. Behind the

door hang the bodies of the wives Bluebeard has murdered; the stain on the key is their blood; and he prepares to kill the new wife for her disobedience until her brothers arrive and kill him. Frances Hodgson Burnett's *The Secret Garden* (1911) supplies the neglected, contrary girl in an old house of locked rooms who finds a key, opens a door in a wall, and grows a living garden. Selick's decision to make Coraline's parents writers of a gardening catalogue who cannot abide dirt reads as a citation of Burnett's opposition between living cultivation and sterile display—an opposition the Other world's garden, blooming into a portrait of its spectator, completes. C. S. Lewis's wardrobe (1950) supplies the domestic portal.

What *Coraline* adds is the bricked door. By day the little door opens onto a wall; by night, onto a corridor. The wall is the primary world's limit, its refusal of passage; the corridor is fantasy's hypothesis that the limit is negotiable. The text's moral architecture depends on the wall's eventual vindication.

Tolkien's "On Fairy-Stories" (delivered 1939, published 1947) furnishes the theoretical frame. Tolkien defended fantasy's three gifts—Recovery, Escape, and Consolation—and distinguished the Escape of the Prisoner from the Flight of the Deserter. *Coraline* inverts the topology on which that defence relies: the fantastic world is the prison, and Escape is the return. Yet the text practises Tolkienian Recovery in its purest form. Tolkien borrowed from Chesterton the word *Mooreeffoc*—'Coffee-room' read backwards through a glass door—to name the estrangement by which the familiar is seen anew. The Other house is Mooreeffoc rendered as architecture: the home read backwards through a small door, from which the child returns able to see her actual home for the first time.

1.3 *Tale-Types and Morphology*

Folkloristics clarifies the structure. Coraline's rescue of the ghost children follows ATU 311, 'Rescue by the Sister,' whose best-known instance is the Grimms' "Fitcher's Bird" (KHM 46): the youngest sister, cleverer than the sorcerer who has murdered and dismembered her two elder sisters for entering his forbidden chamber, finds their bodies there, reassembles them so that they revive, and escapes disguised as a bird, after which her brothers and kinsmen burn the sorcerer and his wedding guests inside his house. Coraline's victory differs in kind: the beldam is sealed away, not put to death. The beldam's feasts recall ATU 327A, 'Hansel and Gretel,' in which, during a famine, the mother persuades the father to abandon the children in the forest, and the witch of the edible house fattens Hansel in order to eat him until Gretel pushes her into her own oven. The beldam reverses the first mother and repeats the second: she overfeeds instead of starving, and she feeds in order to consume. The wager by which Coraline stakes her eyes against the

beldam's captives recalls ATU 500, the 'Rumpelstiltskin' type, in which a child is pledged in a bargain with a supernatural agent and redeemed through cunning and the power of a name—the very power Coraline asserts each time she corrects 'Caroline.'

The descent to retrieve the lost recalls the Homeric *Hymn to Demeter*, inverted. There, Hades seizes Persephone and carries her underground to be his wife, with Zeus's consent—the abduction later titled the 'rape' of Proserpina, from the Latin *raptus*, seizure—and the pomegranate seeds she eats there bind her to the underworld for part of every year, while Demeter searches the earth for her. Here the daughter descends of her own accord, the captor is a mother rather than a male god, the food she eats does not bind her, and it is the parents she must find. Selick's doll inverts the Russian "Vasilisa the Beautiful" (Afanasyev, 1855–63), in which a dying mother gives her daughter a doll that, fed and consulted, guides her through Baba Yaga's ordeals. Vasilisa's doll carries the mother's blessing toward the daughter's autonomy; Coraline's doll carries the beldam's surveillance toward the daughter's capture.

The Grimms' editorial history sharpens the point. In the 1812 first edition of "Snow White," the queen who orders a huntsman to kill the girl and bring back her lungs and liver, and who then eats what she believes are her daughter's organs, is the girl's own mother; by 1819 she has become a stepmother, and the mother of "Hansel and Gretel" undergoes the same conversion in later editions. Maria Tatar (1987) reads these revisions as a sanitising displacement of maternal aggression onto a substitute. Gaiman's *Other* Mother occupies precisely the space the Grimms' editing opened: neither mother nor stepmother but the mother's double, she returns the edited-out ambivalence to the nursery under a name that admits kinship while disowning identity.

Vladimir Propp's *Morphology of the Folktale* (1928) confirms how faithfully the novella runs the classic sequence of functions:

Propp's function	Instance in *Coraline*
Absentation	Parents absorbed in work; the child left to explore
Interdiction	The mice's warning, relayed by the old man upstairs, not to go through the door
Violation	Coraline passes through the door
Reconnaissance and delivery	The beldam's surveillance; in the film, the doll
Trickery and complicity	Feasts, gifts, correct naming; Coraline's provisional enjoyment

Propp's function	Instance in *Coraline*
Villainy	The parents abducted into a snow globe
Receipt of a magical agent	The crones' holed stone; the cat's guidance
Struggle and difficult task	The game for the parents and the ghost children's souls
Victory and liquidation of lack	Escape through the door with parents and souls recovered
Return	Re-entry into the ordinary world
Pursuit and rescue	The severed hand follows; it is trapped in the well

The departures are as telling as the fidelities. Propp's closing functions—transfiguration of the hero and the wedding—are absent. Coraline's transfiguration is perceptual rather than corporeal, and her reward is not a marriage but a renewed bond with the ordinary.

1.4 *The Beldam's Lineage*

The novella's name for its antagonist is *beldam*, from Middle English *bel dame*, 'fair lady,' a courtesy that descended through 'grandmother' into 'hag.' The word's literary history is a history of the maternal and the chthonic. Shakespeare's Hotspur speaks of winds imprisoned within the earth's womb that shake "the old beldam earth" (*1 Henry IV*, 3.1): the beldam is the earth as aged mother whose interior convulses. *Macbeth*'s Hecate rebukes the witches as "beldams" (3.5). And the courtly *belle dame* survives in Keats's "La Belle Dame sans Merci" (1819), whose enchanted knight dreams of her earlier victims: "I saw pale kings and princes too, / Pale warriors, death-pale were they all; / They cried—'La Belle Dame sans Merci / Hath thee in thrall!'" Keats's death-pale procession is the ancestor of Gaiman's ghost children, earlier children she lured with the same offer, button-eyed, and drained of life, whose souls she kept after their deaths and whose testimony warns the newest. The difference is decisive. Keats's victims can only warn; Gaiman's are rescued, by the very child they warn.

Yeats's "The Stolen Child" (1886) supplies the beldam's rhetoric: "Come away, O human child! / To the waters and the wild / With a faery, hand in hand, / For the world's more full of weeping than you can understand." The faery's argument is the beldam's: the primary world disappoints, the elsewhere fulfils. Coraline accepts the faery's premise and reverses its conclusion. The world is fuller of weeping than a child can understand, and for precisely that reason it is worth choosing, since only a world that can disappoint can also surprise.

Christina Rossetti's *Goblin Market* (1862) supplies the economy of seduction by food and its feminist resolution. Laura buys the goblin men's fruit with a lock of her golden hair and then wastes toward death with longing for more. Her sister Lizzie, who has not eaten, goes to the goblins to buy fruit for her; when she refuses to eat it in their presence, the goblin men assault her—"Held her hands and squeezed their fruits / Against her mouth to make her eat"—and she runs home with the juice on her face, telling Laura: "Eat me, drink me, love me; / Laura, make much of me." The poem's moral is sororal: "For there is no friend like a sister / In calm or stormy weather." *Coraline* inverts the gender of the predators—the goblin *men* become a mother—while keeping the structure of the rescue: resistance under coercion, on behalf of those who succumbed. Coraline's refusal of the buttons is Lizzie's shut mouth.

C. S. Lewis's *The Silver Chair* (1953) offers the closest structural precedent. In the underworld the Lady of the Green Kirtle enchants her captives with the argument that the sunlit world is a dream extrapolated from lamps, and the spell breaks only when Puddleglum stamps out her fire with his bare foot, the pain restoring his grip on the real. Coraline's analogue to the burnt foot is her recurrent appeal to bodily realism—cold, hunger, fear, the weight of the key—as a test of the real against the beldam's frictionless dream.

1.5 *The Double Reassignment*

The grammar is inherited; the positions are reassigned. The villain's place passes from the Grimms' sanitised stepmother and from the male predators of tradition—Hades who abducts, the goblin men who assault, the Erl-King who cages girls, Bluebeard and Fitcher who murder wives and brides—to a mother's double. The rescuer's place passes from the brothers who ride to save Bluebeard's wife in Perrault, and from the avenging mother of Angela Carter's 1979 revision, to the daughter herself. This double reassignment is the formal precondition of the dissertation's argument. The text must be able to say that the enemy of a child's freedom wears a mother's face, and that the child can herself institute the separation that saves them both.

CHAPTER TWO

The Unhomely Home

Uncanny Topology and the Ontology of the Copy

II

> *The Other house is the primary house turned inside out—the* heimlich *realised as the* unheimlich*—and its metaphysics is the metaphysics of the copy: a world wholly derivative, indexed to a single spectator, and bounded by nothingness.*

2.1 *Freud and the Return of the Familiar*

FREUD'S "Das Unheimliche" (1919) begins in philology. Pursuing *heimlich* through Daniel Sanders's dictionary, Freud finds that the word for the homely, familiar, and intimate also means the concealed and secret, until it coincides with its own antonym. He adopts Schelling's definition: *unheimlich* is the name for everything that ought to have remained secret and hidden and has come to light. And he concludes that the uncanny is that species of the frightening which leads back to what is long known and long familiar.

The Other house is Freud's essay rendered as real estate. Every room is the familiar room and every face the familiar face; only the eyes are wrong. The uncanny here is not the strange but the excessively familiar: the home as it would appear were its latent wishes fully realised. What 'ought to have remained hidden' and 'has come to light' is the child's own wish for perfect parents, and the horror is that the wish, granted, looks back with buttons.

Freud's essay is organised around E. T. A. Hoffmann's "Der Sandmann" (1816), and the correspondence is exact. Hoffmann's nursemaid tells Nathanael of the Sandman who throws sand into the eyes of children who will not sleep until their eyes spring bloody from their heads, then carries the eyes to the half-moon to feed his own children. The tale's second terror is Olympia, the automaton whose eyes are supplied by the optician Coppola. Freud read the fear for one's eyes as a substitute for castration anxiety. Whatever one makes of that reduction, the button-eye condenses both of Hoffmann's terrors into one object: it is at once the Sandman's theft, the eye removed, and Olympia's prosthesis, the doll's eye supplied.

Ernst Jentsch, whom Freud contested, had located the uncanny in intellectual uncertainty: doubt whether an apparently animate being is alive, or whether a lifeless object might be animate ("Zur Psychologie des Unheimlichen," 1906). Selick's film is an instrument of Jentschian doubt, since every body in it, real or Other, is a puppet. The beldam's project, however, is the decisive resolution of Jentsch's uncertainty in the wrong direction: the conversion of an animate girl into an object.

Otto Rank's *Der Doppelgänger* (1914) supplies the final term. The double, Rank argued, originates as an insurance against death—an immortal soul, a reflection, a shadow—and degrades into death's herald. The Other parents follow Rank's trajectory precisely. Introduced as improvements and guarantees of perfect care, they decay into omens; the novella's Other Father, abandoned in the cellar, dissolves into a pale, half-formed thing, the double's insurance collapsing into the evidence of mortality it was meant to deny.

2.2 *Topoanalysis: The Vertical House*

Gaston Bachelard's *The Poetics of Space* (1958) proposed a topoanalysis of the house as the primary site of reverie, organised by a vertical polarity: the attic, airy and rational; the cellar, the dark and irrational underground. The house in *Coraline* is a vertical psychograph. Above lives the old man with his mouse circus, a reverie of high places, eccentric and lucid; it is from the attic that the warning comes. Below live the retired actresses Miss Spink and Miss Forcible, keepers of the theatre of memory, who replay the past and read the future in tea leaves. Between them is Coraline's flat; and beneath it all, in the Other house, the cellar where the Other Father degenerates—Bachelard's irrational depth, the place where the wish's underside is stored.

The corridor between worlds requires its own reading. In the novella it is dark and musty; in the film it becomes a soft, pulsing, iridescent tunnel. The film makes explicit what the novella implies: the passage is uterine. To go through is to be unborn into the mother's world; to return is to be born again into the ordinary world of other people. Coraline's final passage, dragging the door shut against the beldam's pursuing hand, is a birth the child delivers herself.

2.3 *The Ontology of the Copy*

The beldam's world is wholly derivative: every element is a variation on something Coraline has already seen. This is the metaphysics Plato attacked in *Republic* X, where the imitator stands at the third remove from truth. Yet the beldam is a demiurge of a peculiarly impoverished kind. Plato's demiurge in the *Timaeus* copies eternal Forms; the beldam copies copies. Her cosmos is what Jean Baudrillard (*Simulacres et simulation*, 1981) would call hyperreal: a simulation that does not dissemble a reality but replaces it, more vivid than the original because unburdened by the original's resistance.

Its boundaries confirm the diagnosis. When Coraline walks away from the Other house, the world thins into blankness and returns her to the house: in the novella a featureless mist, in the film a white void in which the cat explains that the beldam made only what she needed to impress the girl. The Other world is perspectival; it exists only where the child looks. It is a stage set, the dome of Peter Weir's *The Truman Show* (1998), a world without an outside—and a world without an outside is a world without others, since what is other is precisely what exceeds the perspective of the one who beholds it.

2.4 *The Cat, or the Being Without a Double*

One creature escapes the economy of the copy. The cat appears in both worlds and is the same in both; in Selick's film, it alone among the Other world's inhabitants has no buttons. It explains in the novella that cats have no names because they know who they are, whereas people need names because they do not. The cat is the text's figure of unduplicated singularity: the one being the beldam cannot copy, rename, or sew. It is also, not coincidentally, the being she hates.

Jacques Derrida, in *L'Animal que donc je suis* (lectures 1997; published 2006), insisted that the cat whose gaze discomfited him was not a figure or an allegory but a real, singular cat, irreducible to the concept of 'the animal.' Gaiman's cat performs the same irreducibility within a fiction. It refuses symbolic capture, the name, and imaginary capture, the double. It marks the limit of the beldam's power and, as Chapter 5 argues, the limit of any humanism that would define dignity by the possession of a name.

2.5 *The Hag Stone*

The crones' gift—a stone with a hole through it—derives from British folk practice, in which naturally holed 'hag stones' were hung against witchcraft and looked through to see the fair folk. Its function in the novella is to reveal the ghost children's souls hidden in the copy-world; it is an instrument for discriminating the authentic from the counterfeit. That it is given by two old women who read tea leaves completes a triad Gaiman returns to across his work: Coraline as maiden, the mother and her double as mother, Spink and Forcible as comic crones. Robert Graves's triple goddess (*The White Goddess*, 1948), which Gaiman reworks in *The Sandman*'s Kindly Ones and in the Hempstock women of *The Ocean at the End of the Lane* (2013), is present here in burlesque. But the crones' gift is serious: it is Tolkien's Recovery made portable, the power to see through the copy to what is real.

2.6 *The Material Uncanny*

Selick's medium gives the uncanny a material register. Masahiro Mori's hypothesis of the 'uncanny valley' (1970) predicted that affinity for humanoid figures collapses as they approach, without achieving, full human likeness. Stop-motion inhabits that valley by vocation: its figures are handmade objects, moved a frame at a time, whose motion is never quite continuous. The production's then-novel use of rapid-prototyped replacement faces multiplied Coraline's expressions into a vast

catalogue of fabricated faces—a technical fact the narrative uncannily mirrors, since the beldam's ambition is precisely to replace a face with a fabricated one. The film therefore stages its uncanny twice: in the story, as a threat to the eyes; in the medium, as the animation of the inanimate.

CHAPTER THREE

The Psychoanalytic Genealogy of Maternal Totality

III

Psychoanalysis supplies the deepest originators of the text's central intuition—that a mother who never fails is a catastrophe—and, read in sequence from Freud through Winnicott and Lacan to the feminist relational theorists, it furnishes the conceptual vocabulary of Maternal Totality.

3.1 *The Family Romance Dissolved*

IN "Der Familienroman der Neurotiker" (1909), Freud described the child's fantasy that its parents are impostors and its true parents nobler. His decisive observation was that the fantasised parents are constructed from the child's earliest perception of the real ones: the 'better' parents are the actual parents as they seemed when the child overvalued them. The family romance is nostalgia disguised as rebellion.

The Other parents are the family romance materialised, and their construction confirms Freud with literal precision: they are copies of the real parents, improved. The Other world is therefore regressive in the strict sense, a return to the infantile overvaluation of an all-supplying mother. Coraline's adventure is the traversal and dissolution of the family romance. She does not discover that her real parents are noble; she discovers that the noble parents are monstrous, and the poor, real ones sufficient.

3.2 *Klein: The Lie of Idealisation*

Melanie Klein's account of the paranoid-schizoid position ("Notes on Some Schizoid Mechanisms," 1946) holds that the infant splits its objects into an idealised good and a persecutory bad, and that idealisation and persecution are correlative: the more the good object is idealised, the more terrifying the bad. Bruno Bettelheim's *The Uses of Enchantment* (1976) adapted this logic to the fairy tale, arguing that the split between good mother and wicked stepmother lets the child preserve a wholly good mother while discharging its rage on a substitute.

Bettelheim's authority carries a caveat. Alan Dundes (1991) documented extensive unacknowledged borrowing in *The Uses of Enchantment* from Julius Heuscher's A *Psychiatric Study of Fairy Tales* (1963). After Bettelheim's death in 1990, former residents and staff of the University of Chicago's Orthogenic School, which he directed from 1944 to 1973, reported that he hit and humiliated the children in his care (Pollak 1997). The theorist of what children need from fairy tales ran an institution in which, on these accounts, an adult's power over children went unchecked.

Coraline inverts Bettelheim. The idealised mother *is* the witch. The Other Mother's metamorphosis from all-giving hostess to clawed predator is not a transformation but a disclosure: the persecutory object was the idealised object all along, exactly as Klein's theory predicts. The text thus refuses the fairy tale's defensive economy, in which the good mother is protected by the invention of a bad one. It says instead that idealisation is the danger, and that safety lies in what Klein called the depressive position: the integration of good and bad into a single,

whole, ambivalently loved person. Coraline's return to a mother who is busy, impatient, and loving is a passage from the paranoid-schizoid world of perfect and monstrous mothers into the depressive world of real ones.

Klein's late work names the decisive affect. In "Envy and Gratitude" (1957), envy spoils the good object because it cannot bear the object's independence, whereas gratitude enjoys the good object without needing to possess it. The beldam is envy personified: she cannot enjoy Coraline without owning her. The novella's final chapter, in which an ordinary late-summer evening is received as a gift, is an education in gratitude.

3.3 *Winnicott: The Mother Who Will Not Fail*

No originator is more indispensable than D. W. Winnicott. In "Transitional Objects and Transitional Phenomena" (1953), he described the good-enough mother as one who begins with an almost complete adaptation to her infant's needs and then adapts less and less, in step with the infant's growing capacity to tolerate her failures. Graduated failure is not a regrettable concession but the mechanism by which reality is introduced and a self constituted. A mother who adapted perfectly forever would be indistinguishable from magic, and the infant would never meet the world.

The beldam is the mother who will not fail. Her perfect adaptation, extended indefinitely, is what Winnicott called *impingement*: an environment that intrudes by anticipating, depriving the child of the gap in which a gesture of its own could arise. Winnicott's distinction between true and false self ("Ego Distortion in Terms of True and False Self," 1960) completes the diagnosis. The false self is built from compliance with an environment that substitutes its gesture for the infant's; the button-eye is the false self's apotheosis, a compliance so total that the organ of spontaneous perception is sealed.

Two further essays sharpen the reading. "The Capacity to Be Alone" (1958) argues that the ability to be alone develops, paradoxically, in the presence of a mother who is there but does not intrude; the beldam, who is everywhere, makes solitude—and therefore selfhood—impossible. "Hate in the Counter-Transference" (1949) insists, scandalously, that the mother hates the infant from the start, and that her capacity to tolerate that hatred without acting on it belongs to good-enough care. The real mother's irritation is thus not a failure of love but a component of it. The beldam, who never admits hatred, enacts it without remainder: her love, unable to acknowledge ambivalence, is hatred that cannot recognise itself.

Selick's doll extends the analysis into the transitional sphere. The transitional object—the blanket, the bear—is the child's first 'not-me' possession, at once found

and created, belonging neither to inner nor to outer reality. The doll in Coraline's likeness is a transitional object colonised: a not-me possession that is in fact the mother's eye. The film thereby identifies the beldam's most insidious operation, the occupation of the intermediate area of play—where the self should be free to make its own meanings—by the gaze of an adult who wants it.

3.4 *Lacan: The Lack of Lack*

Lacan's mirror stage (1949) locates the ego's origin in an alienated image of bodily unity, jubilantly assumed; the Other world is the imaginary in its pure form, a world of seductive images whose wholeness conceals dismemberment. But it is Lacan's seminar on anxiety (Seminar X, 1962–63) that most precisely names the beldam's power. Against the commonplace that anxiety arises from loss of the object, Lacan argued that anxiety arises when *lack itself is lacking*, when the place where desire might open is filled. His example is pointed: what most provokes a child's anxiety is not the mother's absence but the impossibility of her absence, a mother who is always on his back, down to wiping his bottom. The beldam is the lack of lack embodied.

The same seminar contains an image of almost uncanny relevance. To figure the subject's anxiety before the opaque desire of the Other, Lacan imagines himself wearing an animal mask he cannot see, facing a giant female praying mantis, not knowing what he is for her. Selick's film places a mantis-shaped machine in the Other garden, ridden by the Other Father and turned against the child, and the beldam herself culminates in an insectile, arachnid form. The mantis—behind it Roger Caillois's 1934 essay on the mantis as a myth of the female who devours her mate in the act of mating—is Lacan's figure for the question every child addresses to the maternal Other: *Che vuoi*?, what do you want of me? Coraline's achievement is to receive the answer—you, entire, eyes and all—and refuse it.

The distinction between eye and gaze (Seminar XI, 1964) clarifies the buttons. The gaze is not the eye's possession but the point from which the subject is looked at. In the Other world the gaze is everywhere—in the doll, in the button-eyed neighbours—while the eye, the organ of the subject's own looking, is the target of elimination. The beldam would leave Coraline a seen thing that cannot see.

Finally, the Other world lacks what Lacan called the Name-of-the-Father: the symbolic function that separates child from mother by introducing law. The Other Father is a puppet; in the film he apologises even as he is forced to attack. What institutes law in the Other world is Coraline herself, who proposes a game with rules, stakes, and conditions binding on both players. The wager is the paternal metaphor performed by the daughter. This is a feminist revision of the Lacanian

scheme: separation from the totalising mother is not imposed by a father but authored by a girl.

Psychoanalysis has its own name for Maternal Totality: the *phallic mother*. In "Fetischismus" (1927), Freud read the fetish as a substitute for the maternal phallus that the small child once believed in and does not want to give up, an object that lets the subject at once know and disavow that the mother lacks. Later analysts named that fantasy the phallic mother, and Lacan made the child's discovery that the mother lacks, and desires something beyond the child, the hinge of separation. The beldam is the fantasy given a body and equipped accordingly: needles that pierce and sew, fingers that lengthen, a hand that grasps. The buttons are fetishes in Freud's exact sense, objects installed in the place of the organ through which lack is seen.

The ending answers her in the same register. The door Coraline shuts severs the beldam's hand: castration in the structural sense, the inscription of lack on a figure that refused it. The hand that then pursues the key through the primary world is a detached part-object, lack made visible and mobile. Freud's essay on the uncanny supplies the link to the eyes. He reads Oedipus's self-blinding—done, in Sophocles, with the brooch-pins from the robe of Jocasta, his mother and wife, after he finds she has hanged herself—as a mitigated form of castration. The beldam's needles reverse that scene: this time the mother's pins are turned on the child.

3.5 *Kristeva and Creed: The Abject and the Archaic*

Julia Kristeva's *Pouvoirs de l'horreur* (1980) defines the abject as what disturbs identity, system, and order, and identifies the maternal body as the first abject, which the subject must expel to establish its borders. The Other world, as it decomposes, becomes a landscape of abjection: the Other Father's grub-like dissolution, the Other actresses fused into a single two-headed mass, the house collapsing into outline. The beldam's world ends in formlessness because its maker cannot tolerate the border that constitutes form. Kristeva's "Stabat Mater" (first published 1977) offers the counter-image: the Virgin as an idealised maternal without desire of her own. The beldam is the Virgin's photographic negative—a mother with no desire separate from the child, and for that reason all-devouring.

Barbara Creed's *The Monstrous-Feminine* (1993) extends Kristeva into horror cinema, identifying the 'archaic mother' as a parthenogenetic creatrix who generates without a partner. The beldam is parthenogenetic: her world, including its father, is her production.

3.6 *Neumann and the Feminist Dragon-Fight*

Neumann made the dragon-fight the heroic act par excellence and gendered it: the hero's 'solar' consciousness is masculine, the uroboric unconscious feminine. Feminist critics have rightly objected that the schema writes women out of heroism. *Coraline* rewrites it from within. A girl undertakes the dragon-fight, and the dragon is not the feminine as such but the totalising maternal. Maureen Murdock (*The Heroine's Journey*, 1990) recounts that Joseph Campbell told her women need not make the journey, since in mythology the woman is the destination. Coraline's journey answers Campbell: the woman is not the destination but the traveller, and the destination she refuses is the place where she would be kept.

3.7 *Relational Feminist Psychoanalysis*

Nancy Chodorow's *The Reproduction of Mothering* (1978) argued that daughters, mothered by a parent of the same sex, experience a prolonged pre-Oedipal identification that makes separation more difficult and individuation more relational. Coraline's separation is accordingly not a rupture but a renegotiation: she does not leave her mother behind but recovers her mother from captivity.

Jessica Benjamin's *The Bonds of Love* (1988) supplies the logic of that renegotiation. Drawing on Hegel, Benjamin identified the paradox of recognition: the self needs recognition from an other it does not control, since recognition from a controlled other is worthless. Domination is the attempt to resolve the paradox by obliterating the other's independence, and it fails by its own logic. The beldam is the paradox enacted. She wants to be loved by a child whom she would render incapable of the independent act that love is, and so she can only consume.

Luce Irigaray's prose-poem "Et l'une ne bouge pas sans l'autre" (1979) gives the dynamic its most intimate form. The daughter addresses a mother whose nourishment has frozen her—milk that turns to ice, feeding that immobilises—and asks for a relation in which both women can be alive at once, neither disappearing into the other. *Coraline* answers Irigaray's plea in narrative. The beldam's feasts are the milk that freezes; the novella's resolution is two living subjects, mother and daughter, separate and reunited.

3.8 *The Key on a String*

In *Jenseits des Lustprinzips* (1920), Freud watched his grandson throw a wooden reel on a string out of his cot with a sound Freud heard as *fort*, 'gone,' and reel it back with *da*, 'there': a game of mastering the mother's departures. *Coraline* contains its own reel and string. The black key, worn on a string around Coraline's neck, is the instrument of passage between worlds, and the novella's denouement casts it into a well, under cover of a dolls' tea party staged to lure the beldam's severed hand. This is a *fort* without *da*: a game of departure whose final move renounces the return. Freud paired the fort/da game with the death drive, the organism's tendency toward stillness, and the Other world, with its frozen perfection, is the death drive's interior design. Coraline answers it with play—literally a dolls' tea party—turning the instruments of childhood against the force that would make her a doll.

CHAPTER FOUR

Institution, Angel, and Doll's House

Feminist Readings

IV

> *Read through feminist theory, the beldam is not maternal power but the institution of motherhood personified—the Angel in the House grown monstrous—and the text's apparent demonisation of a mother is a defence of real mothers against the ideal that would replace them.*

4.1 *Institution and Experience*

ADRIENNE RICH'S *Of Woman Born: Motherhood as Experience and Institution* (1976) distinguished two meanings of motherhood: the potential relationship of any woman to her powers of reproduction and to children, and the institution that aims to keep that potential under male control. The institution, Rich argued, presents itself as nature, idealises maternal self-sacrifice, and punishes the ambivalence that real mothering involves.

The beldam is the institution personified and freed of the woman who would bear it: a mother consisting entirely of the ideal—total availability, total provision, total devotion—and nothing of the experience, with its fatigue, irritation, and divided attention. The real mother is pure experience. She works; she is short-tempered; in the novella she declines to buy the Day-Glo green gloves her daughter covets; in the film, Mel Jones, neck-braced and deadline-driven, refuses mess, mud, and indulgence. The text's preference for this mother over her perfected double is not misogyny but its opposite: a defence of the woman against the institution that would replace her with an ideal.

Rich closed her book by returning to Demeter and Kore, the mythic pattern of a mother who searches the underworld for a stolen daughter. *Coraline* inverts the pattern: the daughter descends, searches, and retrieves the mother. The inversion expresses a feminism in which the daughter's freedom and the mother's are bound together, so that liberating the one requires liberating the other from captivity in an image.

4.2 *The Angel and the Beldam*

Coventry Patmore's *The Angel in the House* (1854–62) gave the Victorian ideal its canonical formulation: "Man must be pleased; but him to please / Is woman's pleasure." Virginia Woolf's "Professions for Women" (1931) described the Angel—intensely sympathetic, utterly unselfish, sacrificing herself daily, the one who took the leg if there was chicken—and declared that killing her was part of a woman writer's occupation. Kate Chopin's *The Awakening* (1899) found the type in the nursery: "They were women who idolized their children, worshiped their husbands, and esteemed it a holy privilege to efface themselves as individuals and grow wings as ministering angels." Betty Friedan's *The Feminine Mystique* (1963) diagnosed the ideal's mid-century suburban form.

The beldam is the Angel's terminal phase. She serves the roast chicken; she lives for the child; she has, in Chopin's phrase, effaced herself as an individual—except that the self thus effaced returns as appetite. The text's insight is that angel and

monster are not opposites but stages of one figure: a woman forbidden every object of desire except the child will come to desire the child absolutely. The real mother, in this light, has already done what Woolf recommended. She has killed the Angel in the House, and her daughter's resentment of that act gives way to recognition of its necessity.

4.3 *Woman as Other*

Simone de Beauvoir's *Le Deuxième Sexe* (1949) argued that man constitutes himself as Subject and woman as Other, confining her to *immanence*—repetitive, conserving labour—while reserving for himself the *transcendence* of projects that open onto the future. Beauvoir's account of the mother is unsentimental: denied transcendence, the mother may seek it vicariously in the child, and may seek in a daughter a double through whom to relive and redeem her own life.

The beldam's very name literalises the diagnosis: she is woman as *Other*, the role absolutised into an identity. Her world is pure immanence—nothing grows, nothing changes, every day repeats the feast—and her desire for Coraline is the desire for a double, a daughter remade in the image of the doll the beldam has already become. Coraline's choice of the primary world is a choice of transcendence: of a future not already furnished.

4.4 *The Woman-Artist as Witch*

Sandra Gilbert and Susan Gubar's *The Madwoman in the Attic* (1979) read the queen of "Snow White" as a figure of the woman artist—plotter, schemer, maker of disguises and stories—whose creative energy, denied legitimate outlet, is demonised as witchcraft and set against the passive angel-daughter in the glass coffin. The beldam is such a maker. She builds a world, designs its gardens, stages its theatres, animates its creatures. Gilbert and Gubar license a reading the text does not foreclose: the beldam is what maternal creativity becomes when its only permitted object is the child. Her world is a work of art made under confinement, and its monstrosity is that of a genius with nowhere else to go.

Charlotte Perkins Gilman's "The Yellow Wallpaper" (1892) sharpens the point. Its narrator, confined to an old nursery by her husband John, a physician who prescribes the 'rest cure' and forbids her to work—the treatment S. Weir Mitchell had prescribed for Gilman herself—discovers a woman trapped behind the wallpaper's pattern, creeping. The beldam is likewise trapped—bound to her world, able to cross only through the door, waiting behind the wall. A tragic-feminist reading therefore coexists with the horror reading: the beldam is both the prison's

warden and its oldest inmate. Gilman's warden, though, is a husband: John is the physician whom Kant names among the guardians of comfortable minority (Chapter 5), the one who decides the patient's diet, which is why Maternal Totality names a structure of power rather than a sex.

4.5 *The Doll's House*

Mary Wollstonecraft's *A Vindication of the Rights of Woman* (1792) indicted the education that trained girls into ornamental passivity: "Taught from their infancy that beauty is woman's sceptre, the mind shapes itself to the body, and, roaming round its gilt cage, only seeks to adorn its prison." Her target was Rousseau, whose *Émile* (1762) educated Sophie to please. The Other world is a gilt cage furnished for a girl—marvellous clothes, flying toys, a garden in her image—whose condition of entry is that the mind shape itself to the body by consenting to a modification of the face.

Ibsen's *A Doll's House* (1879) supplies the transmission mechanism. Nora tells Torvald, in William Archer's translation, "I have been your doll-wife, just as at home I was papa's doll-child; and here the children have been my dolls." Dollhood is inherited: the doll-child becomes the doll-wife who makes her children dolls. The beldam's project completes the cycle—the transformation of a daughter into a doll—and Coraline's refusal interrupts it. Nora exits through a door; Coraline shuts one, severing the hand that reaches through. Both scenes make the threshold the site of emancipation.

John Stuart Mill's *The Subjection of Women* (1869) supplies the philosophical premise: "What is now called the nature of women is an eminently artificial thing—the result of forced repression in some directions, unnatural stimulation in others." The beldam's femininity is manufactured in exactly Mill's sense, stimulated toward service and repressed in every other direction. Ira Levin's *The Stepford Wives* (1972) imagined the men of the Stepford Men's Association killing their wives and replacing them with compliant robotic replicas—the killings left implicit but unmistakable—in a project led by Dale 'Diz' Coba, a former Disneyland animatronics engineer, assisted by the illustrator Ike Mazzard, who sketches each wife, and the linguist Claude Axhelm, who records her voice. The beldam inverts Levin's scenario—a mother who would replace a child with a compliant replica—and Levin's division of labour anticipates Chapter 6: the replica is made the way an animated figure is made.

4.6 *Masquerade and the Gaze*

Joan Riviere's "Womanliness as a Masquerade" (1929) argued that there is no difference between 'genuine' womanliness and the masquerade a woman may wear to avert reprisal. The beldam is womanliness as masquerade with the mask's lining exposed. Beneath the maternal persona there is not a woman but the beldam, and at the film's end, beneath the beldam, there is nothing: a white void. Judith Butler's account of gender as performative (*Gender Trouble*, 1990)—a stylised repetition of acts without an original—finds its nightmare here: a performance of motherhood so perfectly repeated that it has consumed the performer.

The film's theatre sequence extends the analysis to age. The Other Spink and Forcible emerge from their elderly bodies as young performers before an audience of dogs, a spectacle of femininity as display that the film frames as at once dazzling and grotesque. Laura Mulvey's "Visual Pleasure and Narrative Cinema" (1975) analysed classical cinema's division of labour between the active male look and the woman's 'to-be-looked-at-ness.' The button-eye is that division's limit-case: a body that can be looked at but cannot look. Coraline, by contrast, is defined by looking—an explorer who inventories doors and windows, peers through a holed stone, and wins by seeing what is hidden.

4.7 *Gothic Daughters and Devouring Houses*

Ellen Moers's *Literary Women* (1976) named the Female Gothic: the narrative in which a young woman explores a labyrinthine house, at once persecuted victim and courageous heroine, as in Ann Radcliffe's *The Mysteries of Udolpho* (1794). Coraline is the Female Gothic's child heroine. Her closest precedent is Charlotte Brontë's *Jane Eyre* (1847), whose ten-year-old heroine, after her cousin John Reed strikes her and she fights back, is locked by her aunt and guardian, Mrs Reed, in the red-room where Mr Reed died, and, terrified that his ghost is near, loses consciousness, in a chapter that opens "I resisted all the way"; Coraline, locked behind the mirror by the beldam, meets the ghost children. Jane's adult declaration—"I am a free human being with an independent will"—is the creed toward which Coraline's ordeal moves. Shirley Jackson's *The Haunting of Hill House* (1959) is the counter-case: a house that wants a lonely woman, and a woman who, unlike Coraline, says yes: Eleanor Vance, sent away by the others for her own safety, drives her car into a tree on the grounds and dies, and the house's claim is completed in her death.

Angela Carter's *The Bloody Chamber* (1979) is the indispensable feminist comparison. Carter, who described her work as demythologising, rewrote Bluebeard so that the heroine's mother gallops to the rescue and shoots the

murderous husband, while the key's indelible stain marks the bride's forehead. In "The Erl-King," a forest enchanter keeps girls as caged birds, and the narrator resolves to strangle him with his own hair and set them free. Coraline combines both of Carter's moves and inverts one: she frees the caged children like Carter's narrator, but she rescues the mother rather than being rescued by her.

Toni Morrison's *Beloved* (1987) provides the most searching comparison, and it must be stated exactly. Morrison drew on the case of Margaret Garner, who in January 1856 escaped from slavery in Kentucky with her family across the frozen Ohio River. When her enslaver, Archibald Gaines, came to Cincinnati with federal marshals to reclaim them under the Fugitive Slave Act of 1850, Garner killed her two-year-old daughter, Mary, rather than see her returned to slavery; Garner herself was returned to it.

In the novel, Sethe has been robbed of her motherhood before the killing. At Sweet Home, schoolteacher's two nephews held her down and took the breast milk meant for her baby while schoolteacher watched and wrote it up; when she reported it, one of them whipped her on his order. When schoolteacher later comes to 124 with a nephew, a slave catcher, and a sheriff to reclaim her and her children as property, Sethe kills her infant daughter and tries to kill her other children; the ghost who returns as Beloved is that daughter. Under the doctrine of *partus sequitur ventrem*, the child of an enslaved woman was born her enslaver's property. Sethe's 'thick' love is the claim of a mother whom the law denied any claim at all.

In *Beloved* the ghost-child consumes the mother; in *Coraline* the mother consumes the ghost children. The beldam's possession is the pathology of a mother for whom possessing the child is the only standing she has; Sethe acts as a mother who was allowed no standing at all. The stolen milk gives the comparison its sharpest edge: the beldam feeds in order to keep, while schoolteacher's nephews took the food a mother made for her child to show that neither the milk nor the child was hers. Both texts refuse a simple condemnation of excessive love by tracing it to the conditions that deform it.

4.8 *The Postfeminist Charge*

Parsons, Sawers, and McInally (2008) argue that *Coraline* is a postfeminist fairy tale: it grants the girl agency while locating monstrosity in maternal power, and frames that agency in the individualist idiom of neoliberal self-reliance. The charge has real force, especially against the film. Selick's addition of Wybie, reportedly to give Coraline an interlocutor in the primary world, redistributes the climactic agency: at the well, the boy joins the fight against the severed hand, and the novella's solitary girl becomes half of a partnership with a male helper.

The charge nonetheless misreads the novella's core in three respects. First, the villain is the ideal, not the mother: the text vindicates an insufficient, working, impatient mother against a perfect one, the reverse of postfeminism's characteristic idealisation of the maternal subject who has it all. Second, Coraline's agency is relational, not self-optimising: she acts for the ghost children, in alliance with a cat, guided by two old women, on behalf of parents who cannot save themselves. Third, the text pluralises its household. The house is divided into flats; its elders include two women who have shared a life and a career and a solitary man with his mice; its most authoritative being is a cat without a name. Jack Halberstam's *The Queer Art of Failure* (2011), which reads failure as a refusal of normative success, illuminates this plurality: the primary world is a commons of eccentric insufficiencies, and the beldam's perfection is the norm it resists.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Dignity of the Unfinished

Humanist Readings

V

> *The humanist tradition, from the Renaissance through the Enlightenment to existentialism, has repeatedly located human dignity in what is unfixed, unfinished, and unpossessed. The beldam's offer is a precise negation of each of its formulations.*

5.1 *Pico: No Face of One's Own*

PICO DELLA MIRANDOLA'S *Oratio* (1486), the manifesto of Renaissance humanism, places in God's mouth a speech to Adam: *Nec certam sedem, nec propriam faciem, nec munus ullum peculiare tibi dedimus, o Adam*—"We have given you, Adam, no fixed seat, no face of your own, no function peculiar to you, so that whatever seat, whatever face, whatever function you choose, you may have and possess by your own judgment and decision." Human dignity, for Pico, is the absence of a fixed nature: the human being is the creature that shapes itself, ascending or descending the scale of being by choice.

The beldam's offer negates Pico's charter clause by clause. She proposes a fixed seat (the Other house, forever), a face of one's own (button-eyed and final), and a peculiar function (to be loved as a possession is loved). *Propriam faciem* could serve as her entire programme. To accept the buttons is to receive a face of one's own in exactly the sense Pico's God withheld: a face given, finished, and closed to further choosing.

5.2 *Montaigne: The Common Human Pattern*

Montaigne's final essay, "De l'expérience" (*Essais* III.13), closes with two sentences that read like a gloss on *Coraline*'s ending. "We seek other conditions because we do not understand the use of our own, and go out of ourselves because we do not know what it is like within." And: "The most beautiful lives, to my mind, are those that conform to the common and human model, with order, but without miracle and without extravagance." Montaigne's is a humanism of the ordinary: dignity lies not in ascent beyond the human condition but in its intelligent inhabitation. Coraline seeks another condition because she does not yet understand the use of her own, and she returns having learned it.

5.3 *Kant: Comfortable Minority*

Kant's "Beantwortung der Frage: Was ist Aufklärung?" (1784) defines enlightenment as the human being's exit from self-incurred minority, the inability to use one's own understanding without another's direction, and adopts Horace's motto *Sapere aude*: have the courage to use your own understanding. Kant's account of why minority persists describes the beldam's world: "It is so comfortable to be a minor! If I have a book that understands for me, a pastor who has a conscience for me, a physician who decides my diet for me, and so forth, I need not exert myself at all." The guardians, Kant continues, having first made their domestic cattle dull, carefully

ensure that these placid creatures dare not take a single step outside the walking-frame in which they have penned them.

The *Gängelwagen*, the infant's walking-frame, is an image from the nursery, and it is Kant's figure for benevolent tyranny. The beldam is the perfect guardian: she decides the diet, supplies the entertainment, names the child correctly, and asks only that the child never step outside. Coraline's *Sapere aude* takes a literal form: the courage to keep her eyes.

Kant's moral philosophy supplies a second principle. The Formula of Humanity in the *Grundlegung zur Metaphysik der Sitten* (1785) commands that humanity be treated always as an end and never merely as a means. The beldam treats children as means in the most literal sense, as nourishment. The ghost children's testimony—that she drained their lives and kept their souls—makes explicit what her love implies: the beloved is a resource.

5.4 *Hegel: Counterfeit Recognition*

Hegel's *Phänomenologie des Geistes* (1807) describes self-consciousness as achieved only through recognition by another self-consciousness, and stages, in the dialectic of master and servant, the failure of recognition extracted by domination: the master, recognised by a consciousness he has reduced to a thing, receives a recognition worth nothing. Alexandre Kojève's lectures (1933–39; published 1947) radicalised the point into a theory of desire as desire for another's desire.

Coraline translates the dialectic into the most elementary act of recognition: naming. In the primary world the adults call her 'Caroline'; in the Other world everyone gets her name right. The beldam's seduction is a seduction by recognition, and it is counterfeit, because a world that exists only for Coraline cannot recognise her. Recognition requires an independent other who might have failed to recognise. The misnaming neighbours are therefore, paradoxically, the condition of real recognition, since theirs, when it comes, will be free. Coraline's persistent correction of her name is not petulance but the assertion of standing in a world of others who must be persuaded.

5.5 *Fromm: Love in the Mode of Being*

Erich Fromm's *The Art of Loving* (1956) argued that the essence of motherly love is care for the child's growth, and therefore the wish for the child's separation: the test of a mother's love is not devotion to the infant but willingness to let the growing child go. In *To Have or to Be?* (1976), Fromm distinguished love in the mode of *having*—possession, control, hoarding—from love in the mode of *being*, an

activity that renews and enlarges the beloved. The novella's simile of the miser and the dragon is Fromm's mode of having in the idiom of the fairy tale. Fromm's *Escape from Freedom* (1941), with its analysis of the flight from freedom's burden into submission, names the temptation the Other world presents: not tyranny but relief from having to choose.

5.6 *Existence, Bad Faith, and Courage*

Sartre's lecture *L'existentialisme est un humanisme* (1946) declared that for the human being existence precedes essence: we are first, and define ourselves afterward through action. The beldam proposes essence before existence, a self delivered complete. To accept it would be what *L'Être et le néant* (1943) calls bad faith, the flight from freedom into the fixity of a thing. Sartre's analysis of the look, the Other's gaze that turns me into an object, illuminates the buttons once more: to be button-eyed is to be the object of the look without the power to return it.

Camus, in *Le Mythe de Sisyphe* (1942), condemned 'philosophical suicide,' the leap from the absurd into consoling transcendence. The Other world is such a leap, a consolation purchased by abandoning the real; Coraline's return to her grey world is the absurdist's fidelity, and one must imagine her, like Sisyphus, happy. Paul Tillich's *The Courage to Be* (1952) defined courage as the self-affirmation of being in spite of the threat of non-being. The white edges of the Other world, the void encircling the beldam's creation, are non-being given a topography, and Coraline's courage is to affirm her finite being against it.

The novella makes courage an explicit theme. In one of its quietest passages, Coraline recalls a day when her father, on a patch of waste ground, told her to run and stood still while wasps stung him, then went back for the glasses he had dropped; he later explained that what made the going back brave was that he had been afraid. Coraline derives her own definition: bravery is doing the frightening thing while frightened. This is Aristotle's *andreia*, the mean between cowardice and rashness, a courage that knows fear—transmitted by a father who appears in most readings as merely an ineffectual cook. The insufficient parent has already given the child what the perfect one never could: an example of acting for another under fear.

5.7 *Arendt: Natality*

Hannah Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) grounded the human capacity for action in *natality*: each birth introduces a new beginning into the world, and action reactivates that capacity for the unprecedented. The beldam's world is anti-natal. Nothing in it is new, everything in it copies, and its purpose is to arrest a child's beginning by finishing her. Coraline's return to the primary world is a return to the only kind of world in which something can begin.

5.8 *The Experience Machine*

Robert Nozick's thought experiment in *Anarchy, State, and Utopia* (1974) asked whether one would plug into a machine able to supply any desired experience, and argued that most would refuse: we want to *do* things, not merely to have the experience of doing them; we want to *be* a certain kind of person; and we want contact with a reality deeper than one of human manufacture. The Other world is the experience machine furnished as a home. Coraline's refusal—her insistence that a world in which she received whatever she wanted would not mean anything—is the most concise statement of Nozick's intuition in children's literature.

The refusal inverts Plato's allegory of the cave (*Republic* VII). In Plato the real is brighter than the shadows; in *Coraline* the shadow-world is brighter—the film saturates the Other world with colour and drains the primary world to greys and browns—and the girl chooses the dim real over the luminous image. Guy Debord's *La Société du spectacle* (1967) defined the spectacle as a social relation mediated by images; Adorno and Horkheimer's *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (1944/1947) argued that the culture industry perpetually cheats its consumers of what it perpetually promises. The beldam's world is both: a spectacle that substitutes images for relations, and a culture industry whose single product is the promise of total satisfaction.

5.9 *Boredom as a Humanist Good*

Coraline begins in boredom: rainy days, absorbed parents, nothing to do but explore. The boredom is not a flaw in the child's environment but its precondition. Kierkegaard's aesthete in *Either/Or* (1843), proposing the 'rotation of crops' against boredom, embodies the futility of perpetual novelty. Heidegger's lectures of 1929–30 analysed 'profound boredom' as an attunement in which beings as a whole withdraw and Dasein's own possibilities are disclosed. Walter Benjamin, in "Der Erzähler" (1936), figured boredom as a dream-bird brooding over the egg of

experience. Adam Phillips's essay "On Being Bored" (1993) drew the developmental consequence: the child's capacity to be bored is an achievement akin to Winnicott's capacity to be alone, and adults who rush to fill it prevent the child from discovering what she wants.

The beldam is the adult who abolishes boredom. Her entertainments are unending; her world has no rainy afternoons. In abolishing boredom she abolishes the interval in which desire forms, and so abolishes desire. The primary world's dullness is restored, by the novella's end, to its proper dignity as the incubator of a self.

5.10 *Diotima's Lack*

The originating formulation of the lacunary anthropology belongs to Plato. In the *Symposium*, Socrates recounts Diotima's teaching that Eros is the child of Poros and Penia, Resource and Poverty, and is therefore perpetually needy, perpetually resourceful, never in possession of what it desires. Desire is lack, and a being without lack would be without love. From Diotima through Hegel and Kojève to Lacan runs a single thread: the subject who desires is the subject who lacks. The beldam's world, which leaves nothing to be desired, is a world in which love is impossible, and her demand for love is self-defeating at the root.

5.11 *Humanism's Limits and the Cat*

Lacunary humanism must answer humanism's critics. Wollstonecraft and Beauvoir showed that the universal 'man' of humanist discourse excluded women. Rosi Braidotti's *The Posthuman* (2013) and Donna Haraway's "A Cyborg Manifesto" (1985) argue that the humanist subject—autonomous, rational, self-possessed, implicitly male and European—is a historical construction to be exceeded. Lacunary humanism accepts much of this critique. Its subject is not the Vitruvian figure of plenitude but a constitutively lacking being, and its dignity rests not on mastery but on a finitude shared with the women excluded from the old humanism, with children, and with animals.

Here the cat returns. Derrida, naked before his cat's gaze, found the boundary between human and animal unsettled by a singular other who looks back. The cat in *Coraline*, which refuses a name and resists every copying, is the text's acknowledgement that the dignity Coraline defends is not exclusively human. A humanism of the lack includes its own limit: the being that cannot be named, possessed, or sewn.

CHAPTER SIX

Metamedia

Animation, Suture, and the Self-Indicting Fantasy

VI

> *Both texts recognise themselves in the beldam. Each is an adult-made world designed to captivate a child, and each converts that recognition into a critique of its own medium.*

6.1 *Adaptation as Second Reading*

SELICK'S ALTERATIONS ARE INTERPRETIVE acts. The relocation to Oregon; the addition of Wybie and of his grandmother, whose twin sister vanished in childhood, which makes the beldam's predation a matter of local history; the doll; the colour design; Bruno Coulais's score, whose children's choir sings in largely asemantic syllables, as though the Other world's music were language before meaning; the mantis; the web. Two additions bear directly on the argument: the needle-hands of the credits, and the Other Wybie, rendered mute because Coraline had wished the real boy would talk less. The latter makes literal what the novella implies—that the beldam's world is the tyranny of a child's own wishes, granted without remainder, in the tradition of W. W. Jacobs's "The Monkey's Paw" (1902).

6.2 *Anima: An Animated Film About De-animation*

'Animation' derives from *anima*, soul: the animator lends motion, and so the appearance of soul, to dead matter. The beldam does the reverse. She takes souls from living children and leaves them as husks, and she proposes to convert a living girl into a perfected doll. *Coraline* is therefore an animated film about de-animation, a work in which the medium's founding act is mirrored by its villain's inverse.

Ovid's Pygmalion (*Metamorphoses* X) sculpts an ideal woman and prays her into life. The beldam is Pygmalion reversed: a maker who would sculpt a living girl into an ideal and so still her. The male artist's fantasy of animating the perfect woman and the maternal tyrant's fantasy of de-animating the perfect daughter are two halves of a single ideology—the ideal as the death of the actual.

6.3 *The Needle-Hands*

The film's credits show needle-tipped metal hands unpicking an old doll and refashioning it in Coraline's likeness. The sequence is a self-portrait of the medium: LAIKA's artisans, too, sewed, knitted, sculpted, and dressed puppets by hand. The film opens by showing its makers in the image of its monster.

Sergei Eisenstein, in notes on Disney written in the early 1940s, celebrated animation's 'plasmaticness'—the freedom of drawn forms from any fixed shape—as a utopian protest against the rigidity of industrial life. The beldam is plasmaticness as tyranny: a maker who can assume any form and reshape any creature, for whom the omnipotence of the animator is the omnipotence of the possessor. The film

thus asks of itself the question the novella asks of the beldam: what does the maker want of the child for whom the world is made?

6.4 *Suture*

Film theory has a name for the operation the beldam proposes. Jacques-Alain Miller's "La suture" (1966) defined suture as the relation of the subject to the chain of its discourse, in which the subject figures as a lack the chain closes over. Jean-Pierre Oudart (1969) carried the concept into cinema, and Daniel Dayan (1974) and Kaja Silverman (*The Subject of Semiotics*, 1983) elaborated it as the process by which classical film stitches the spectator into the fiction, closing through shot and reverse shot the gap opened by awareness of an absent field. Suture is cinema's sewing: the binding of a lacking subject into a world that conceals its own making.

The button-eye is suture's emblem, sewn into the face of the subject. A film released in stereoscopic 3D, whose technology promises an Other world of greater depth, tells the story of a child invited to be stitched into such a world forever—and the film refuses its own invitation. It returns its heroine, and its spectator, to the desaturated primary world, now seen differently. The pleasure of immersion is offered and then exposed as the beldam's pleasure. The spectator is unsewn.

6.5 *The Impossibility of Children's Fiction*

Jacqueline Rose's *The Case of Peter Pan, or the Impossibility of Children's Fiction* (1984) argued that children's fiction constructs the child as the object of adult desire: the adult writes, the child is written for, and the transaction secures the child for the adult's investment. Maria Nikolajeva's concept of *aetonormativity* (2010) names the adult normativity that governs children's literature, and Perry Nodelman's *The Hidden Adult* (2008) traces the adult presence concealed in texts for the young.

The beldam is a children's author in Rose's sense. She builds an enchanting world for a child in order to keep the child. *Coraline* therefore contains its own critique: Gaiman, an adult, builds an enchanting world for a child reader, and the subject of his story is the danger of enchanting worlds built by adults for children. The novella resolves the paradox by its ending, returning its reader with its heroine to the ordinary world—enchanting the reader only in order to release her. J. M. Barrie's *Peter and Wendy* (1911) opens with the sentence "All children, except one, grow up," and its story belongs to the one who does not. *Coraline* belongs to a child who chooses to.

6.6 *Aura and the Handmade*

Benjamin's essay on technical reproducibility (1935–36) defined *aura* as the unique presence of a work in time and space, withered by mechanical copying. The Other world looks like aura's negation, a reproduction without the original's resistance. Yet the film complicates the opposition, because in stop-motion everything is handmade, and the Other world, more richly crafted than the primary one, is the film's showpiece. Its ethic therefore cannot be a romance of craft against copy. It concerns the intention of craft: whether the made thing is offered to be entered and left, or built to hold.

6.7 *The Doll Redux*

The doll is the point at which the film's critique of its medium meets the culture beyond it. A toy that watches a child on behalf of an absent adult is no longer a fairy-tale conceit. In 2017 Germany's Federal Network Agency classified the internet-connected doll 'My Friend Cayla' as a prohibited concealed surveillance device and advised parents to destroy it. The beldam's doll anticipated a regulatory category by eight years.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Arachnopoetics

Weaving, Making, and the Two Ethics of Creation

VII

> *The spider is the text's governing figure of the maker, and its tradition distinguishes two webs: the web that captures and the filament that bridges. I call the poetics that judges making by this distinction* arachnopoetics.

7.1 *Arachne and the Feminist Text*

OVID'S ARACHNE (*Metamorphoses* VI) is a mortal weaver who challenges Minerva to a contest. Minerva weaves the gods in majesty; Arachne weaves what Ovid calls 'heavenly crimes' (*caelestia crimina*), which are, scene after scene, the gods' deception and rape of mortal women—Jupiter with Europa, Leda, and Danaë among many others, and Neptune, Apollo, and Bacchus beside him—so perfectly that the goddess can find no flaw. Minerva tears the tapestry and strikes Arachne with her shuttle; Arachne hangs herself; and Minerva lets her live, but as a spider suspended from her own thread (*vive quidem, pende tamen, improba*: 'live, then, but hang, insolent one'). Nancy K. Miller's "Arachnologies" (1986) took Arachne as the emblem of the woman writer whose text bears the signature of a gendered body and whose work is punished as presumption. What is punished in Ovid is precise: a woman's accurate record of divine sexual violence.

Behind Arachne stand Penelope, who weaves by day and unweaves by night to defer an unwanted marriage, and Philomela, whom Tereus, king of Thrace and husband of her sister Procne, raped and then silenced by cutting out her tongue. Philomela wove an account of the crime into cloth and sent it to her sister—the 'voice of the shuttle' that Aristotle cites from Sophocles' lost *Tereus*, and that Patricia Klindienst Joplin made the title of a feminist essay (1984). The tradition is not innocent: having read the cloth, Procne killed her own son, Itys, and served him to Tereus at a feast. Testimony and devouring meet in a single myth, so the two webs this chapter distinguishes are not two kinds of maker but two possibilities within every making. Above them all, the Moirai spin, measure, and cut. In this tradition weaving is women's speech and women's fate, the craft through which the silenced testify and the powerless defer.

The beldam belongs to this lineage, and the text knows it. She is a maker—in the film a knitter, sewer, and animator—whose craft is her power. What distinguishes her from Arachne, Penelope, or Philomela is the direction of her weaving. Theirs testifies, defers, and resists; hers encloses.

7.2 *Maman*

Louise Bourgeois's spider sculptures, culminating in *Maman* (1999), are the indispensable counter-image. Bourgeois described the spider as an homage to her mother, a restorer of tapestries: clever, patient, protective, and useful, a weaver who repairs. Yet *Maman* is also menacing—towering, long-legged, carrying a sac of marble eggs. Bourgeois holds together the ambivalence that the beldam splits apart: the spider-mother as both shelter and threat. Her mother's craft, moreover,

was repair, which is Klein's *reparation* in textile form: the restoration of a damaged object in acknowledgment of one's own destructiveness. The beldam does not repair. She replaces.

7.3 *Two Webs*

Walt Whitman's "A Noiseless Patient Spider" (1868) gives the second web its classic statement. The spider, isolated on a promontory, "launch'd forth filament, filament, filament, out of itself," and the poet's soul does likewise, casting threads into the vacant surrounding "Till the bridge you will need be form'd, till the ductile anchor hold, / Till the gossamer thread you fling catch somewhere, O my soul." Whitman's web reaches toward an other it does not control and cannot guarantee. It is a bridge, not a trap.

E. B. White's *Charlotte's Web* (1952) brings the figure into children's literature. Charlotte weaves words into her web to save a friend, dies at the end of a single season, and her children, released on threads of silk, drift away—a few to stay, most to go. Charlotte is the relinquishing spider-mother: her making is for another, and her maternity culminates in dispersal.

The beldam's web inverts every term. It is woven to catch, not to reach; it is for herself, not for the other; and it culminates not in dispersal but in retention. At the film's climax the furnishings of the Other world dissolve into a single web at whose centre the beldam waits, the world revealed as what it always was: an instrument of capture whose beauty was bait.

7.4 *Needle and Key*

Two instruments govern the text. The needle closes: it sutures, stitches, and seals the eye. The key opens: it unlocks the door, admits passage, and can lock it again. The beldam's instrument is the needle; Coraline's is the key. The denouement makes the key's last use its renunciation. Cast into the well, it closes the passage for good. The child's final act of making is an unmaking: she does not weave a counter-world but cuts the thread between worlds, completing in her own register Penelope's nightly unweaving.

7.5 *Arachnopoetics Defined*

Arachnopoetics, as proposed here, judges any act of making—a mother's, an author's, an animator's, a designer's—by a single criterion: whether its threads bind or bridge. A web that binds is measured by what it retains; a filament that bridges is measured by what it allows to reach elsewhere. The novella and the film spin a web of extraordinary seductiveness and then cut the reader loose. The works perform an arachnopoetic self-correction: having figured their own making in the spider at the centre of the trap, they end as the filament that lets go. The claim concerns what the works do; it is not a testimonial for their makers (see the note on the author in the Introduction).

CHAPTER EIGHT

Lacunary Humanism

Five Propositions

VIII

> *The preceding chapters converge on a single claim: the protected lack is at once a feminist and a humanist good. This chapter states the claim as five propositions and a corollary, tests it against objections, and reads the novella's ending as its proof.*

8.1 *Two Mothers, Ten Lenses*

THE CONVERGENCE CAN BE read across the traditions assembled above. Each lens, developed independently and for different purposes, sorts the two mothers in the same way.

Lens	The beldam: Maternal Totality	The real mother: insufficiency
Freud	The family romance materialised	The parent beyond idealisation
Klein	Idealised object revealed as persecutory	Whole object, ambivalently loved
Winnicott	Perfect adaptation; impingement	Good-enough; graduated failure
Lacan	The lack of lack; anxiety	Lack preserved; desire possible
Rich	Motherhood as institution	Motherhood as experience
Beauvoir	Immanence; the daughter as double	Transcendence; the daughter as other
Kant	Guardian of comfortable minority	Occasion of maturity
Hegel and J. Benjamin	Recognition extracted by domination	Recognition from an independent other
Fromm	Love in the mode of having	Love in the mode of being
Arachnopoetics	The web that binds	The filament that bridges

8.2 *The Propositions*

Proposition I: the Axiom of Lack. The subject is not the bearer of a lack that ought to be filled but the effect of a lack that ought to be kept. Desire (Diotima, Lacan), recognition (Hegel, Benjamin), freedom (Pico, Sartre), and futurity (Arendt) are functions of the gap; whatever closes the gap closes the subject. The button is the axiom's negative proof.

Proposition II: the Principle of Maternal Totality. The most complete form of domination is not deprivation but perfect provision. Kant's comfortable minority, Lacan's lack of lack, Winnicott's impingement, Nozick's machine, and the culture industry's total promise are versions of one structure. In modern Western culture its most intimate historical form has been the ideal of the all-supplying, self-effacing mother. Maternal Totality is gendered because the institution is

gendered, not because maternity is, and its first victims are mothers, whom it replaces with an ideal they cannot be.

Proposition III: the Right to Insufficiency. Every subject holds a right to be failed well and to fail well: to boredom, frustration, misrecognition, and an unfinished self. The right is reciprocal. It protects the daughter from the possessive gaze and the mother from the impossible ideal, which is why the feminist critique of the institution and the humanist defence of the unfinished subject are one argument. It must be distinguished from neglect. bell hooks (*All About Love*, 2000) insisted that abuse and neglect are the opposites of care; insufficiency is care that leaves room, neglect the absence of care. Coraline's parents are insufficient, not negligent, and the father who stood among the wasps is the proof.

Proposition IV: the Ethics of the Unsewn Eye. The faculty proper to both feminist critique and humanist judgment is a vision that remains open to what it cannot possess: the explorer's eye, the hag stone's aperture, Tolkien's Recovery, Kant's courage to use one's own understanding. To keep one's eyes is to keep the capacity to be wrong, to be surprised, and to be confronted by the other as other. Suture, in every medium, is this ethic's adversary.

Proposition V: Relinquishing Poiesis. The ethical measure of any making—parenting, authorship, animation, design, governance—is the maker's willingness to release what is made. The good-enough world, like the good-enough mother, is built to be outgrown.

Corollary: the Beldam Paradigm. Any system that secures attachment by abolishing lack—domestic, aesthetic, economic, or technological—instantiates the beldam, whatever the gender of its operators.

8.3 *Objections and Replies*

Conservatism. It may be objected that *Coraline*, like L. Frank Baum's *The Wonderful Wizard of Oz* (1900), whose heroine insists that "There is no place like home," merely sanctifies the hearth. But Dorothy's grey Kansas is affirmed as home despite its greyness. Coraline's home is affirmed not as sufficient but as insufficient, and its insufficiency is the ground of the affirmation. The moral is not that there is no place like home but that there is no place like a place that lacks.

Postfeminism. As argued in Chapter 4, the target is the ideal, not the mother; the agency is relational, not self-optimising; and the film's partial recontainment through Wybie is a real divergence from the novella rather than its essence.

The nuclear family. The household the text affirms is plural: a house shared by a family, two elderly women, a solitary man, and a cat. The reunited family is one tenancy within a commons.

Romanticised neglect. Proposition III's distinction answers the charge: the right to insufficiency presupposes care.

Psychoanalytic universalism. The psychoanalytic originators are used here not as universal laws of development but as historically situated theories. Their convergence with the feminist and humanist traditions—different idioms, arising from different problems, arriving at the same structural insight about lack—is itself the evidence.

8.4 *The Ending as Proof*

The novella's last chapter is the proof of the five propositions, because nothing in the primary world has been improved. The neighbours are still eccentric, the parents still work, and the house is still old. What has changed is Coraline's perception. The ordinary world is received with gratitude in Klein's sense and seen with the freshness of Tolkien's Recovery. It is enchanted in the manner C. S. Lewis defended in "On Three Ways of Writing for Children" (1952), where he argued that a child who reads of enchanted woods does not despise real woods but finds them a little enchanted. In a dream, the freed ghost children take their leave.

Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973) imagined citizens who abandon a utopia whose happiness depends on one suffering child. Coraline does more than walk away. She walks back to free the children on whom the beldam's paradise fed. Then the well is covered and the key is gone, and the world, with all its lacks, is open.

CONCLUSION

The Unsewn World



> Coraline *is not a story about a bad mother. It is a philosophical fable about the political economy of satisfaction, in which the most dangerous power is the one that gives everything and the most precious possession is the gap it would close.*

I *Contributions*

FOR CHILDREN'S LITERATURE STUDIES, the dissertation proposes that *Coraline* answers Jacqueline Rose's 'impossibility' of children's fiction not by denying the adult's investment in the child but by dramatising it as the beldam and renouncing it in the form of the ending: a fantasy that enchants in order to release. For feminist theory, it proposes Maternal Totality as an analytic that locates monstrosity in the institution of motherhood rather than in mothers, and so converts an apparently misogynist text into a defence of the insufficient mother. For humanist ethics, it proposes lacunary humanism, a humanism grounded in shared finitude rather than in plenitude, and therefore compatible with the feminist and posthumanist critiques that dismantled its predecessors. For media studies, it reads the button-eye as the emblem of suture and the film as a work that exposes and refuses its own immersive power.

II *Coda: The Beldam Paradigm in the Attention Economy*

The beldam's techniques have become infrastructural. Digital platforms greet users by name, adapt to their preferences with a precision no parent could match, abolish the empty interval with endless feeds, and learn from every gesture in order to anticipate the next. Tim Wu's *The Attention Merchants* (2016) traced the industrial harvesting of attention; Shoshana Zuboff's *The Age of Surveillance Capitalism* (2019) described an 'instrumentarian' power that seeks not to compel behaviour but to predict and shape it. In the vocabulary developed here, these are systems of Maternal Totality: perfect adaptation without graduated failure, correct naming without recognition, the abolition of boredom in the service of retention. The beldam's buttons have become a design pattern.

Coraline offers children, and the adults who read to them, an education for this condition. It teaches that a world which knows your name does not thereby recognise you; that the most dangerous offer is the offer of everything; and that boredom, frustration, and the experience of being failed are not deficits to be engineered away but the conditions under which a person can come to want something of her own.

Chesterton's fairy tales taught children that dragons can be beaten. *Coraline* teaches something harder: that the dragon may offer everything, may know your name, may love you as dragons love gold—and can still be beaten, by a child who prefers a world with something missing. Its heroine is the first citizen of a humanism for which the protected lack is the precondition of freedom. She keeps her eyes. She closes the door. She throws away the key. And she walks back into a

world that will disappoint her, because only such a world can also surprise her, and only in such a world can anything begin.

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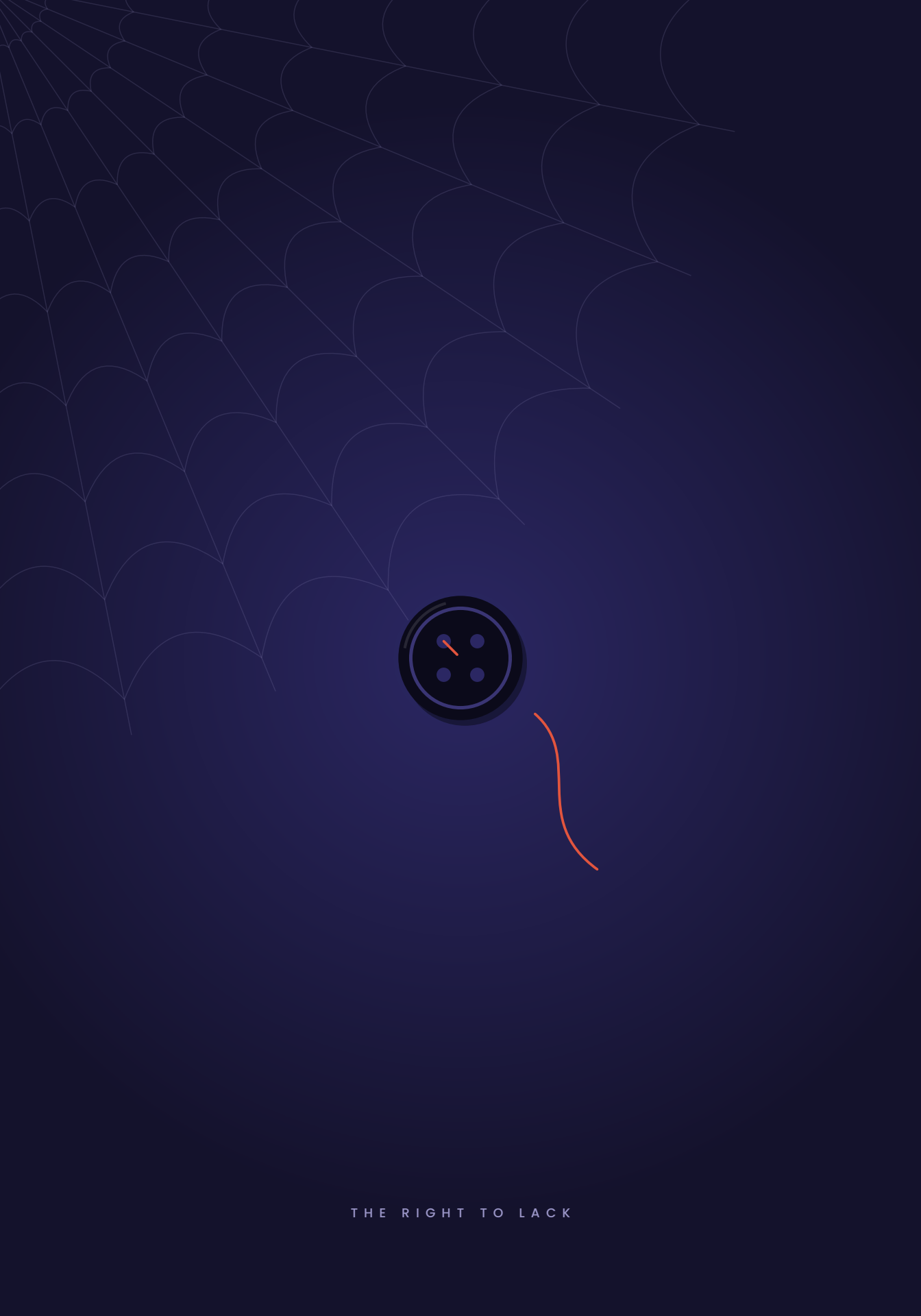
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INDEXING TERMS

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Coraline · Neil Gaiman · Henry Selick · LAIKA · stop-motion animation · children's literature · children's Gothic · Female Gothic · fairy-tale studies · folkloristics · Propp · tale-type ATU 311 · the uncanny (*das Unheimliche*) · the double · topoanalysis · psychoanalytic criticism · object relations · Melanie Klein · D. W. Winnicott · good-enough mother · transitional object · Jacques Lacan · lack · desire · anxiety · the gaze · suture · abjection · the monstrous-feminine · archaic mother · maternal studies · motherhood as institution · mother–daughter relations · recognition · feminist theory · masquerade · performativity · Renaissance humanism · Enlightenment · existentialism · natality · experience machine · boredom · posthumanism · animal studies · adaptation studies · aetonormativity · arachnopoetics · lacunary humanism · Maternal Totality · right to insufficiency · relinquishing poiesis · beldam paradigm · attention economy · surveillance capitalism



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